

# THE INDEPENDENT

No. 308

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

**T**he Independent almost wasn't The Independent. When the founders of the paper were taking the brave, even foolhardy, decision to start a new newspaper in 1986 – the first quality national paper to launch for more than a century – a variety of names were considered: Arena, The Examiner, The Nation, The Chronicle and 24 Hours.

All promising, but all fell short of truly capturing the essence. "The Independent" did so. And it inspired one of the most famous and successful marketing campaigns in media history, with the slogan: "It is. Are you?"

The first edition appeared on Tuesday 7 October 1986. It was an upstart paper, capitalising on the new technologies, financial revolutions and trade union reforms of the time, all of which made a new broadsheet feasible. There was a gap in the market. The competition was tired and partisan, and its founders found little difficulty in attracting funding and talent from across Fleet Street. The Independent stood for social and economic liberalism, and a fresh style. The informal, internal motto is "classic with a twist". With the generous support of its proprietors over the decades, notably Tony O'Reilly and Evgeny Lebedev, the adventure continued, and it now thrives as a global digital brand.

In an essay about its history, the founding editor, Andreas Whittam Smith, once commented: "To say that somebody is independent-minded indicates no particular profile. It simply defines an attitude. You immediately recognise the independent-minded when you meet them."

As a reader, you can be who you want to be, stand for whatever you want to stand for. The Independent stands independent of political party allegiance, and makes its own mind up on the issues of the day.

The Independent titles have stuck to that, guided by inspired editors, including Andrew Marr, Rosie Boycott, Ian Jack, Janet Street-Porter and Simon Kelner. It campaigned against the American and British-led invasion of Iraq in 2003.

As world opinion moves slowly towards a more liberal, enlightened and medically driven attitude towards a "war on drugs" that is unwinnable, The Independent can reflect that it and its sibling, The Independent on Sunday (launched in 1990), led the debate on this too.

The Independent has always been brave; compelled, for example, to use the shocking image of a drowned three-year-old Syrian refugee, Alan Kurdi, to confront the human cost of the migrant crisis in 2015. Since then, The Independent has continued to campaign hard for the humane treatment of those seeking refuge.

On the UK's great issue of the past decade, Brexit, The Independent campaigned with unprecedented force for a "Final Say", clear in our belief that the British people should decide the ultimate relationship with Europe. That remains unfinished business.

The Independent also made up its mind before most that climate change was an existential threat to life on Earth, based on a growing body of scientific evidence.

When, in 2007, Tony Blair described The Independent as a "feral beast", and "avowedly a newspaper not a newspaper", he misunderstood its values. Yet in doing so he inadvertently paid a great compliment. The Independent was happy to publish it.

Some fine writers provided world-class scoops. Robert Fisk's interviews with an obscure mujahideen leader named Osama bin Laden were a very early warning of what was to come. Patrick Cockburn tried to alert the world to the rise of so-called Islamic State long before any other journalist had noticed the threat.

The Independent has always been "condemned to innovate". It has many "firsts" to its credit. It was the first British newspaper to add a Saturday magazine; the first broadsheet to go tabloid; the first to give stunning photography the same prestige as news or features; the first to challenge the Westminster lobby system of closed briefings ("a self-satisfied cabal"); the first to launch a concise quality compact paper, in 2010; the first to launch an edition for children; and the first to go fully digital, in March 2016.

In recent times, public events and reader-oriented debates have been added to the mix, as well as Independent TV.

Today, the boundaries of The Independent's influence are growing wider and wider.

In ways that only digital technology can deliver, The Independent is more receptive to its readers than ever before. It still is "independent", and so are they.